

To the Members of the Florida Legislature

Subject: Florida Must Stop Managing Homelessness and Start Engineering Its Elimination

Members of the Florida Legislature:

Florida has an opportunity to confront one of the most persistent failures of modern public policy: the inability of a wealthy, technologically advanced society to guarantee that its people have a safe place to live.

This is not merely a Florida problem. Florida should be understood as a warning to the United States—and, more broadly, to the Western world—about what happens when homelessness is treated primarily as a problem of visibility, public order, enforcement, or individual behavior rather than as a measurable systems problem involving housing supply, income, health, family stability, mental health, addiction, displacement, and access to services.

Florida's current statutory framework demonstrates the tension. State law generally prohibits counties and municipalities from allowing regular public camping or sleeping on public property, while permitting narrowly defined designated sites under specified conditions. Those designated sites must provide sanitation and access to behavioral-health services, among other requirements. ([Florida Senate](#))

Meanwhile, Florida's Department of Children and Families acknowledges that the state's homelessness system already encompasses emergency shelters, outreach, rental assistance, and rapid rehousing through local Continuums of Care. ([Florida DCF](#))

The question, therefore, should no longer be:

“How do we manage people experiencing homelessness?”

The question should be:

“What combination of housing, economic, health, transportation, prevention, and service interventions mathematically drives the number of people entering homelessness toward zero?”

That is a fundamentally different question.

I. Florida Should Become a Laboratory for Mathematical Futurology

I propose that Florida establish a statewide **Mathematical Futurology of Homelessness Initiative**.

Mathematical futurology should be understood here as the systematic use of mathematics, statistics, simulation, optimization, forecasting, operations research, and scenario analysis to design better futures.

Instead of merely counting homeless people after they become homeless, Florida should construct a dynamic model of the entire homelessness pipeline:

At-Risk Population → Housing Loss → Homelessness → Shelter → Permanent Housing → Housing Stability

The state should measure every transition.

For example:

$$H(t) = H(t-1) + E(t) - R(t) - P(t)$$

where:

- **H(t)** = homeless population at time t
- **E(t)** = new entries into homelessness
- **R(t)** = people successfully returning to stable housing
- **P(t)** = people prevented from entering homelessness

The objective should be mathematically explicit:

Minimize H(t) over time.

Ultimately:

$$\lim H(t) \rightarrow 0$$

The state should not merely ask whether a program is popular, compassionate, punitive, or politically attractive.

It should ask:

How many people did the program prevent from becoming homeless?

How many people did it permanently house?

How many returned to homelessness?

How much did it cost per successful housing outcome?

How quickly did it produce that outcome?

Those are measurable questions.

II. Stop Treating the Street as the Beginning of the Problem

A person sleeping on a sidewalk is not necessarily where the homelessness crisis began.

The causal chain may have started months or years earlier:

- unaffordable rent;
- eviction;
- job loss;
- domestic instability;
- medical expenses;
- disability;
- mental-health challenges;
- substance-use disorders;
- family breakdown;
- insufficient emergency savings;
- inadequate supportive housing;
- lack of transportation;
- discharge from institutional systems without stable housing.

A serious mathematical model must therefore measure **risk before homelessness occurs**.

Florida should build a statewide housing-risk index capable of identifying populations experiencing rapidly increasing probability of housing loss.

That would permit government to intervene before the crisis reaches the street.

The principle is simple:

Prevention should be cheaper than rescue.

If a \$2,000 intervention prevents a household from entering a homelessness system that subsequently costs tens of thousands of dollars in shelter, emergency medical care, policing, court involvement, and repeated service utilization, prevention is not merely humanitarian.

It is economically rational.

III. Housing Capacity Must Be Treated as Infrastructure

Florida cannot mathematically eliminate homelessness without sufficient housing.

Therefore, the state should maintain a continuously updated **Housing Capacity Equation**:

Housing Surplus = Available Affordable Units – Housing Need

If the result is negative, the system is structurally incapable of eliminating homelessness.

This should be treated similarly to electricity, water, transportation, or hospital capacity.

A government would never seriously attempt to eliminate electricity shortages while refusing to measure electricity generation capacity.

Likewise, it cannot eliminate homelessness while failing to continuously measure the relationship between housing demand and affordable housing supply.

Florida should therefore publish, by county:

1. Total housing stock.
2. Vacant units.
3. Affordable rental units.
4. Extremely low-income units.
5. Supportive housing units.
6. Emergency shelter capacity.
7. Average rent.
8. Median household income.
9. Eviction filings.
10. Homelessness entries.
11. Successful permanent-housing placements.
12. Returns to homelessness.

This would transform homelessness policy from rhetoric into engineering.

IV. Create a Statewide Homelessness Digital Twin

Florida should build a **Digital Twin of its homelessness system**.

A digital twin is a computational representation of a real-world system that can be used to simulate alternative futures.

The legislature could ask:

What happens if Florida creates 10,000 additional supportive-housing units?

What happens if rental assistance increases by 20%?

What happens if eviction prevention funding doubles?

What happens if mental-health treatment capacity increases by 30%?

What happens if counties eliminate administrative delays in housing placement?

What happens if affordable housing construction accelerates?

Instead of waiting five years to discover whether a policy worked, policymakers could model multiple scenarios before allocating billions of dollars.

Every major homelessness expenditure should have a projected outcome.

V. Florida's Enforcement Strategy Should Be Evaluated by Outcomes

Florida's restrictions on public camping and sleeping represent a policy choice concerning public spaces. But enforcement alone cannot mathematically eliminate homelessness.

If one person is removed from one location and subsequently appears somewhere else, the geographical coordinates have changed while the underlying variable has not.

That is not elimination.

It is displacement.

Recent reporting from Fort Lauderdale illustrates this problem: city officials have continued to debate how to improve their homelessness strategy, while local officials have emphasized the difficulty of enforcement when people relocate and the need for better data to identify service gaps and repeat homelessness. ([Axios](#))

Florida should therefore establish a statewide metric:

Net Homelessness Reduction = New Permanent Housing – New Homelessness Entries – Returns to Homelessness

Every intervention should be evaluated according to whether it improves this quantity.

VI. Learn From Europe—Without Romanticizing Europe

Europe should not be treated as a utopia.

European countries continue to experience severe housing exclusion, and FEANTSA's 2025 overview reports that homelessness continues to rise in most European countries. The organization argues that housing affordability, welfare policy, and the availability of adequate housing are central to the crisis. ([FEANTSA](#))

That is precisely why Europe provides an important comparative laboratory.

The United States and Europe can compare:

- Housing First systems;
- social housing;
- rental assistance;
- homelessness prevention;
- supportive housing;
- eviction protections;
- municipal housing strategies;
- mental-health services;
- data systems;
- welfare-state interventions.

The purpose should not be to copy Europe blindly.

The purpose should be to determine **which variables actually reduce homelessness**.

VII. West Africa Must Also Be Included in the Equation

The global housing crisis cannot be understood exclusively through a Western lens.

West African cities face a different but interconnected set of challenges involving rapid urbanization, informal settlements, inadequate infrastructure, insecure tenure, poverty, and limited access to formal housing.

The appropriate mathematical question is therefore not simply:

“How many people sleep on American streets?”

It is:

“How many people lack secure, adequate, affordable housing—and why?”

UN-Habitat’s 2026 World Cities Report describes the global housing crisis as the product of insufficient investment, rapid urbanization, economic instability, displacement, and other structural forces. It estimates that up to 3.4 billion people lack secure, safe, and adequate housing globally, including more than one billion people living in informal settlements and slums. ([UN-Habitat](#))

That means Florida’s homelessness crisis is one manifestation of a much larger global housing-system problem.

The United States, Europe, and West Africa have different institutions and economic conditions, but they share a common mathematical variable:

Housing capacity must keep pace with human need.

When it does not, housing insecurity increases.

VIII. Establish a Florida Homelessness Command Center

Florida should create a permanent interdisciplinary institution combining:

Mathematics + Economics + Urban Planning + Public Health + Housing + Data Science + Behavioral Health + Social Services.

Its mission should be simple:

Reduce homelessness every year.

The center should publish a quarterly dashboard containing:

1. Homelessness inflow

How many people entered homelessness?

2. Homelessness outflow

How many people obtained permanent housing?

3. Recidivism

How many returned to homelessness?

4. Prevention

How many people were prevented from becoming homeless?

5. Housing production

How many affordable and supportive units were created?

6. Cost efficiency

How much public money was spent per successful permanent housing outcome?

7. Geographic concentration

Where is homelessness increasing?

8. Predictive risk

Where is homelessness likely to increase next?

Government should then allocate resources according to predicted need rather than waiting for crises to become politically visible.

IX. Adopt a 2030 Mathematical Target

Florida should establish a measurable statewide objective:

By 2030, Florida should achieve sustained reductions in both homelessness inflow and the number of people experiencing unsheltered homelessness, while substantially increasing permanent housing exits and preventing returns to homelessness.

Importantly, the target should not be achieved through statistical manipulation.

The state should independently audit the numbers.

A person does not cease to be homeless merely because the government changes the definition, moves the person across a county line, or relocates the person into an unstable temporary arrangement.

The ultimate metric should be:

Stable housing.

X. The Western World Needs a Different Philosophy

Florida's experience should matter far beyond Florida.

The United States has enormous technological capacity.

Europe possesses extensive institutional and social-policy capacity.

West Africa possesses enormous demographic and urban-growth potential.

Yet the global housing system remains incapable of guaranteeing secure housing to enormous numbers of people.

UN-Habitat has described homelessness as a structural crisis connected to inequality, unaffordable housing, and weak social protection and has called for governments to move beyond short-term emergency responses toward longer-term housing solutions. ([UN-Habitat](#))

This should force a fundamental reconsideration.

The 20th-century welfare state asked:

“How do we help people who have fallen through the cracks?”

The 21st-century mathematical state should ask:

“Why does the system continue producing cracks?”

That is the question Florida should lead the United States in answering.

XI. A Challenge to the Florida Legislature

Members of the Legislature:

Florida should not measure success by how effectively it removes homelessness from public view.

It should measure success by how effectively it removes the conditions that produce homelessness.

There is an enormous difference between:

moving homeless people

and

moving people into permanent housing.

There is a difference between:

reducing visible encampments

and

reducing homelessness.

There is a difference between:

spending money on homelessness

and

purchasing measurable reductions in homelessness.

And there is a difference between:

managing a crisis

and

engineering its eventual elimination.

Florida has the data.

Florida has universities.

Florida has engineers.

Florida has economists.

Florida has hospitals.

Florida has technology companies.

Florida has housing developers.

Florida has public agencies.

Florida has nonprofit organizations.

What is needed is an integrated mathematical architecture that connects these capabilities around one measurable objective.

Make homelessness a solvable systems problem.

Model it.

Measure it.

Predict it.

Prevent it.

Build for it.

Intervene earlier.

Evaluate every dollar.

And relentlessly drive the number downward.

Florida has the opportunity to demonstrate that a modern government does not have to choose between compassion and fiscal discipline, nor between public order and human dignity.

It can pursue both by designing systems that make stable housing the measurable endpoint.

The Western world should be watching.

And West Africa should be included in that conversation—not as an afterthought, but as a critical partner in developing the next generation of global housing policy.

The future of homelessness policy should not be determined solely by ideology.

It should be determined by **evidence, mathematics, experimentation, human dignity, and measurable outcomes.**

Respectfully,

[Name]

Proponent of Mathematical Futurology